

29 A, an or the

1 Compare a and an:

We use **a** before words which begin with consonants (b, c, d, f, g, h, j, k, l...):

a doctor - **a** big car **a** girl

We also use **a** before **u** when it sounds like the word 'you', and before **eu**:

university (sound: 'you'): **a** university

a European city

We use **an** before words which begin with vowels (a, e, i, o, u):

an apple **an** interesting film

We also use **an** before words that begin with a silent **h**. Compare **hour** and **house**:

hour (sound: 'our'): **an** hour

house: **a** house

2 Compare a/an and the:

Mary: I bought **a** CD player and **a** TV yesterday.

~ Joe: Was **the** CD player expensive?

We usually use **a/an** with a noun to talk about a person or thing for the first time:

a CD player

We use **the** when we talk about the person or thing again:

the CD player (= the one that Mary bought)

3 There are some special uses of a/an and the:

▶ We use **a/an** with prices, frequency and speeds:

*It costs £2 **a** litre.*

*I drink about three cups of coffee **a** day.*

*You're driving at ninety miles **an** hour!*

▶ We use **a/an** before **hundred, thousand, million**:

***a** hundred people **a** thousand days*

▶ We use **a/an** for talking about jobs:

*I'm **a** bank manager.*

▶ We use **the** when there is only one of something:

*May I turn on **the** TV?*

(There is only one TV in the room.)

*Where's Mary? ~ She's in **the** kitchen.*

(There is only one kitchen in the house.)

▶ We use **the** with musical instruments:

*I play **the** guitar. Jane plays **the** violin.*

Practice

A Put a or an in the gaps.

0 I bought a new car yesterday.

0 It's an old film.

1 She's reading an interesting book.

2 They've got a house in Spain.

3 It's a cheap restaurant.

4 He's a Italian businessman.

5 The journey took a hour.

6 We've lost a black cat.

7 I want to buy an umbrella.

8 It was a difficult exam.

B Now finish the sentences using a or an and the correct phrase from the box.

0 Steven Spielberg is an American director.

1 Tokyo is a Japanese city.

2 Heathrow is an English airport.

3 The Ganges is a European country.

4 Oxford is a university town.

5 A Mercedes is a German car.

6 Spain is a European country.

European country
Indian river
~~American director~~
university town
Japanese city
English airport
German car

C Put *a*, *an* or *the* in the gaps in these conversations.

- 0 Joanna: What did you do yesterday evening?
Peter: I watched an interesting programme on TV. Then I had something to eat and I read a book.
Joanna: What was the programme about?
- 1 Steve: I've bought a jumper. I'm going to give it to Joanna for her birthday.
Cathy: Really? Can I see _____ jumper?
- 2 Mary: Hello, Carol! What are you doing here?
Carol: I'm waiting to speak to the manager of this shop. I bought _____ TV here yesterday, and it doesn't work.
Mary: Oh, I'm sorry. I bought _____ radio here and it's very good. Was _____ TV expensive?
- 3 Chris: _____ police car and _____ ambulance stopped in my street this morning.
Jimmy: Do you know why?
Chris: Well, _____ police car stayed for five minutes, and then _____ ambulance left with one of my neighbours inside.
- 4 Joy: I'm going to have a meal in _____ Japanese restaurant tonight.
Mike: I'm going to _____ disco. Do you want to meet me at _____ disco after you've eaten?
- 5 David: How long have you lived here?
Philip: Ten years.
David: Really? Have you got _____ flat or _____ house?
Philip: I've got both! _____ flat is in the centre of town. It's very small. _____ house is by the sea.

D There are some mistakes in these sentences. Put a tick (✓) if you think the underlined word is correct. Cross it out and change it if you think it's wrong.

- 0 I'm not sure what she does, but I think she's a ✓ doctor.
- 0 I saw the a thousand different things when I was on holiday.
- 1 Be careful! That perfume costs £100 a bottle.
- 2 We must invite him to the party. He plays a piano and a guitar.
- 3 A: What does John do?
B: I'm not sure, but I think he is the teacher in a school.
- 4 She likes to drive at the hundred miles an hour.
- 5 I play the violin in an orchestra. They pay me £50 the day!
- 6 I've got the hundred jobs to do before we leave.
- 7 A: Is my handbag in the living-room?
B: No, it isn't. I saw it in a kitchen.